



Ages 11 to 14

Racism: What It Is and What to Do

What racism can look like, why it's never just banter, what to do if it happens to you or a friend, and where to get help. For all students.

Before You Read This guide talks about racism and racist bullying.

This guide is about racism, including racist names, "jokes" and bullying about someone's skin colour, family background or religion. It describes these things but never repeats racist words. Some of it might feel close to home. That's OK.

- Read it in bits, take a break, or stop whenever you need to.
- You can talk to any adult you trust at school, including the safeguarding team, a counsellor or the school nurse.
- **Childline** is free and confidential. You can call 0800 1111 any time, day or night. You can also use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk), but you may have to wait for a counsellor, so calling is usually quickest.

If you or someone else is in danger right now, call 999.

This Guide Is for Everyone

Everyone has the right to feel safe and welcome at school, whatever their skin colour, family background, religion, language or where they come from. This guide explains what racism is, what to do if it happens to you or someone else, and where to get help.

- Racism can come from anyone, and be aimed at anyone.
- If it's happening to you, **it is not your fault**, and you don't have to sort it out on your own.
- If you've said something racist, you can stop, learn and put it right.

Need Help Now?

- **Tell an adult you trust:** a teacher, your tutor, a house parent or anyone at school you feel safe with.
- If someone has threatened you or someone else, **tell an adult straight away.**

- If someone has hurt you, or you're scared of being hurt, **tell an adult straight away**.
- If someone is in danger right now, **call 999**.
- **Childline**: 0800 1111, free, any time.

What Do the Words Mean?

Racism

Treating someone badly, or saying hurtful things, because of their skin colour, family background, nationality or culture.

Slur

A nasty name for a group of people. Slurs are used to hurt and put people down.

Stereotype

An unfair idea that everyone from one group is the same. Stereotypes can lead to bullying.

Faith-targeted abuse

Picking on someone because of their religion, such as antisemitism (against Jewish people) or anti-Muslim hatred.

Bystander

Someone who sees what is happening. Bystanders can help, safely, by getting an adult.

Trusted adult

An adult you feel safe with: a teacher, tutor, coach, house parent, counsellor or family member.

Joke or Racism?

A Joke Between Friends

- Everyone is laughing, including the person it's about
- It stops when someone says they don't like it
- It isn't about who someone is

Racism

- It picks on someone's skin colour, family, religion, accent, name or food
- It uses a slur, even "as a joke"

- The person it's about isn't laughing, or laughs just to get through it
- It makes someone feel scared, small or left out

Racist "jokes" are not banter. They hurt, even when the person doesn't show it. **You don't have to wait for it to happen again before you tell an adult.** Once is enough.

What It Can Look Like

- Racist names or slurs, in person or online
- Mocking someone's accent, name, hair, clothes or food
- Telling someone to "go back" to where they're "from"
- Pulling at someone's hair, headscarf or other religious clothing
- Leaving someone out because of who they are
- Racist memes, stickers or videos in group chats

If It Happens to You

What to Do

- **Get away if you can**, and go to an adult or somewhere with people you trust.
- **You don't have to answer back.** Staying quiet doesn't mean you let it happen. It is never your fault.
- **Tell a trusted adult**, today if you can. You won't be in trouble, and telling is the right thing to do.
- **If it's online:** keep it. Don't delete. You don't need to save or screenshot anything: an adult can help. If you need to block someone now to feel safe, do it, and tell an adult anyway.
- **Look after yourself.** Spend time with people who make you feel good about who you are.

You Don't Have to Be a Detective

- You don't have to prove what was said, find witnesses or keep a record of everything.
- You don't have to face the person who said it, or say sorry for anything.

- Sorting it out is the adults' job.

RESPOND: If It's Happening to Someone Else

Most people see racism happen to someone else. What bystanders do makes a big difference, but **you never have to confront anyone**. Here is what you can do.

You Lead (R, E, S)

R

Recognise

Notice the signs.

- Is someone being called names or "joked" about because of who they are?
- Has a friend gone quiet, or started avoiding people or places?
- You don't need to be sure to do something

E

Engage

Help, if it is safe to do so.

- **Get an adult** straight away. That's the most useful thing you can do
- **Change the subject**, or give your friend a reason to leave with you: "Come on, we're late"
- **Check in afterwards**: "I saw what happened. Are you OK?"
- Don't laugh, join in or film it

S

Support

Be there.

- "That wasn't OK. It's not your fault. I'm on your side."
- Keep including them

The Bridge: Pause (P)



Pause

Stop and think.

- **Don't share, like or forward** racist posts or videos, even to show people how bad they are
- Don't get into a fight or a shouting match
- Don't promise to keep it secret if someone could get hurt

Adults Lead (O, N, D)



Offer

Show them there's help.

- Tell your friend a trusted adult can help, and offer to go with them



Notify

Tell a trusted adult.

- Tell an adult what you saw and heard. You don't have to repeat the words
- That isn't snitching. It's how people get help



Document

Adults write it down.

- The adult will make a record. You just need to tell them what happened



Telling an Adult

What Happens When You Tell

- **It starts with someone you trust.** Behind them is a team whose job is to make sure you get the right help.
- The adult will listen and take what you say seriously.
- They won't make you face the person who said it, or make you shake hands. They'll make a plan with the school's safeguarding team to keep you safe.

- If an adult is worried about your safety, they will share the concern with the school's safeguarding team. They will explain what happens next and involve you as much as possible in decisions about keeping you safe. They won't promise to keep it secret.
- Adults who work with young people are allowed to share information that helps keep children safe without asking your permission. They only share what is needed, and only with the people who need to know. They will tell you what they are sharing and why, unless that would put someone in danger, and they will listen to what you think.
- You will be kept informed and asked what you need.

If You've Said Something Racist

Sometimes people repeat things they've heard online, at home or from friends, or say something to fit in or get a laugh. It still hurts the person it's aimed at.

- Stop, and think about how it felt for them.
- Talk to an adult you trust. Owning up is better than waiting to be found out.
- There will be consequences, and there will also be help to understand why it matters and to do better.
- If something at home or online is making you think this way, you can talk about that too. The adult will think carefully about how, and whether, your family is told.
- **Childline** (0800 1111) is there for you too.

Myths and Facts

Myth	Fact
"It's just banter"	Jokes about someone's race or religion are racism, not banter. They hurt, even if the person laughs.
"If they didn't say anything, they didn't mind"	Lots of people go quiet when they're hurt or scared. Silence doesn't mean it's OK.
"Telling is snitching"	Telling an adult is how racism gets stopped. It's the right thing to do.

"You can't be racist if you're from a minority too"

Anyone can say something racist, whatever their background.

"Words can't really hurt"

Racist words can make people feel unsafe and unwelcome for a long time.

If You Board

- **You can always contact your house parents, the DSL or a member of the boarding management team, at any time, day or night.**
- If it happens in your boarding house, tell a house parent, even late in the evening. You don't have to wait until morning.
- Your boarding school has an independent person you can talk to who isn't a member of staff.
- You can always contact your family privately.

Who Can Help

At School

- Any adult you trust: your tutor, a teacher, a coach, a house parent if you board, or a school counsellor
- **The Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL)** and deputy DSLs: the staff whose job is to keep students safe. Their names are usually on the school website, in the safeguarding policy and on posters around school.
- The school nurse or health centre, and the school counsellor

Outside School

- **Childline (for anyone under 19):** 0800 1111, free and confidential; call any time, day or night, or use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk) (you may have to wait for a chat counsellor, so calling is usually quickest). **If you're under 18, start here.** Childline also has advice on racism and racial bullying.
- **Shout:** text **SHOUT** to 85258, free, confidential, 24/7

- **Call Hate Out (Stop Hate UK, for under-18s):** confidential 24-hour support if you experience or see hate, in the areas Stop Hate UK covers (check at stophateuk.org)
- **Emergency:** call 999

RESPOND Safeguarding Framework Student Guides

Racism: What It Is and What to Do: Student Guide 1 - 11 to 14

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